



Jewish refugees make their way to Palestine. Thousands attempted this journey before Britain stopped allowing illegal entry into Palestine.

REPRESENTATIVES OF 51 NATIONS BEGAN THE YEAR BY FORMING the United Nations (UN) General Assembly, the successor to the League of Nations (see 1919). Its aims were to provide a forum for the nations of the world and to **uphold peace and security**.

The peace after World War II was short-lived, as relations between **Western allies** and the **Soviet Union** continued to cool. In March, **Winston Churchill** summed up the threat of communism in a speech that described an **"iron curtain"** falling across Europe.

The Soviet Union tightened its grip on Europe by creating **"satellite states."** **Communist governments** were set up in Czechoslovakia, Bulgaria, Albania, Poland, Romania, and Hungary. In France and Italy, communist parties narrowly missed seizing control.

Tensions increased in **India** following Britain's declaration that India would gain **independence** after the war. The leader of the Muslim League, **Muhammad Ali Jinnah** (1876–1948), demanded a **separate Muslim state**, while Hindus opposed this idea. On

“AN IRON CURTAIN HAS DESCENDED ACROSS THE CONTINENT.”

Winston Churchill, British politician, March 5 1946

August 16, Jinnah declared a **Direct Action Day**, a mass protest against British proposals for an all-India government. Violent fighting erupted and thousands died. In response, **Mohandas Karamchad Gandhi** (1869–1948) began a campaign for reconciliation between Hindus and Muslims.

The US granted **independence** to the **Philippines** in July, though the gift had strings attached: the **US kept sovereignty** over several military bases, the Philippine economy was dependent on US markets, and a "parity" clause gave US citizens equal economic rights with Filipinos.

The drive for liberation in **Africa** continued with the establishment of the **Pan-African Federation** by **Kwame Nkrumah**, from Ghana, and **Jomo Kenyatta**, from Kenya. They aimed to promote African unity and end racial discrimination.

In **Palestine**, conferences were held to resolve the growing crisis of admitting **Jewish refugees into Palestine**, but no agreement was reached. The problem was compounded in August, when boats carrying refugees were blocked by **British warships**. Britain told the US it would no

longer allow illegal entry into Palestine, igniting a diplomatic war.

Civil war resumed in China, having been suspended during the world war. The communist leader **Mao Zedong** (1893–1976) declared war on the ruling Kuomintang nationalist party and its leader **Chiang Kai-shek** (1887–1975).

France remained determined to hold on to its colonies in Indochina, beginning one of the longest **guerrilla wars** in history. In November, clashes intensified between the Viet Minh, led by **Ho Chi Minh** (1890–1969), and the



Juan Perón
Fiercely nationalistic, anti-US, and anti-communist, Perón pledged a "Third Way" between capitalism and communism.

Dead Sea Scrolls

The discovery of the Dead Sea Scrolls was one of the most important archaeological finds of the century. The scrolls are fragments of manuscripts of the Old Testament.

Far East Expeditionary Corps, led by France. **The First Indochina War**, involving the rebellion of Vietnam, Cambodia, and Laos against France, was declared on December 19 (see 1954).

The Argentine former secretary of labor, **General Juan Domingo Perón** (1895–1974), was installed as president of Argentina on June 4. With strong working-class support and military backing, he promised **social security** and **higher wages**.

Technicians at the University of Pennsylvania began operating the **first practical electronic digital computer**. The machine was first used for military purposes. It occupied 1,800 sq ft (167 sq m), had 18,000 vacuum tubes, and weighed almost 50 tons.



The division of post-war Europe
After the war, Britain, France, and the US occupied West Germany, while the Soviet Union controlled East Germany. Lithuania, Latvia, Moldavia, and Estonia were absorbed into the USSR.

